



Decision Maker

	Cost-effective solution	SoHo with a dedicated Internet connection	SoHo with a dial-up connection
You need	A decent performing mail server software to help you get started with e-mailing solutions with minimal cost	A software that accepts or sends e-mails outside the organisation, and also supports e-mail transfer within the organisation	A software with the capability to download e-mails from, or send them at regular intervals to, an external server
Look for	Basic features such as downloading mails, as well as forwarding mails to an external server	Security features such as anti-virus and the ability to prevent unauthorised users from connecting to the server	Downloading as well as security features such as anti-virus, screening of computers, etc
Our pick	qmail for Linux, Office Mail for Windows	qmail for Linux, IMail for Windows	Merak Mail
Price	Free	qmail: Free; IMail for Windows: Free for 10 users	US\$99 (Rs 4,950 approx.)

Setting up a Mail Solution

SCENARIO 1: You need to provide an e-mail solution that allows employees to send, as well as receive e-mails, only within your organisation. In this case, you just have to install any of the nine server software, and you're done. You can specify any domain name, even something like microsoft.com, intel.com, etc., as long as you don't want to send and receive e-mails to and from outside the organisation. Configure the user accounts on the server, and then configure the SMTP server to sort the incoming mails to the respective inboxes. Finally, for all the e-mail clients, configure settings for the POP3 and SMTP servers such that they use the IP address of the mail server.

SCENARIO 2: You need to provide a solution that allows employees to send and receive e-mails from outside the organisation as well. For this, you need a domain name such as **www.mycompany.com** or **www.mycompany.co.in**, so that you have a global presence. Here's how you go about doing this:

STEP 1 First, check whether the domain name of your choice is open for registration. You can view the status for any top level domain such as .com, .org, .net, .info, .biz and .name on any of the registrar's Web sites, such as netsol.com, whois.net, register.com, etc. All '.in' domains, where .in represents India, are registered with NCST, India at <http://ncst.ernet.in>.

Just type in the domain name in the appropriate box and click on the search option. In case the domain's registered, it displays the contact details of its current owner. If it's not, then register it manually with the help of a company. If it's already registered, then either choose a new name, or wait for the current holder to release the domain. You can even offer to buy the domain rights from the current holder.

Possible domain name options are mycompany.org, mycompany.net, mycompany.biz and mycompany.info. An even better domain would be something like mycompany.co.in, where '.co.in' indicates that the company is registered in India.

STEP 2 Register your domain name either online, or with the help of a local vendor. If you decide to register online, remember to have your credit card handy.

Web sites such as BulkRegister.com and Register.com, etc. are appointed as Accredited Registrars for the United States.

USA itself has a lot of companies that are authorised to accept domain registrations. The entire registrar list is available at <http://www.inter-nic.net/origin.html>. India has its own set of accredited registrars too—directi.com and Signdomains.com, for instance.

Registering a domain name for a year via the Web costs you anywhere in the range from Rs 700 to Rs 1,700, after dollar conversion, while registering the same with the help of a local vendor may amount to something as low as Rs 400.

STEP 3 You now need to buy a domain-hosting package. This involves buying space on an Internet e-mail server (IES) that's always connected to the Internet. This way, a storage space marked with your domain name stays online all the time.

There are several hosting companies providing such facilities. Each vendor has a set of systems connected to the Internet 24x7. These companies link the IES to the domain name.

STEP 4 This is when you set up the DNS servers to link the domain name and the IES. Most domain hosting companies provide mailing solutions as part of the hosting package. So, if you buy a hosting plan, you get a certain number of mailboxes on the IES.

Some companies provide a separate space for each mailbox. Some provide a single chunk of space, which the user can custom-divide amongst the mailboxes. These companies also provide a control panel to manage your Web site. This helps you create, modify, delete users, manage databases, view site statistics, protect the directory, etc. Here, too, we're restricting ourselves to features needed to enable mailing solutions.

STEP 5 Next, create users with the help of the control panel. Depending on the number of mailboxes provided (usually between 5 and 20), create all the user accounts on the

